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Duffy Jackson

Drummer Duffy Jackson seemed destined to become an integral part of some of the finest rhythm sections in jazz. His father is Chubby Jackson, the driving bass player behind the greatest of Woody Herman's Thundering Herd. Duffy took to the drums at an early age, receiving tips from Herman's drummer Don Lamond, and sitting in with the Basie orchestra at age 12. He was playing with pianist Monty Alexander while still in high school, and went from graduation to a west coast gig with Ray Brown and Milt Jackson. He went on to play with Sammy Davis Jr., Illinois Jacquet, Lionel Hampton and Artie Shaw. Duffy has toured with the Count Basie Orchestra on three separate occasions and considers his time with "America's Greatest Rhythm Section" to be among his proudest accomplishments. As a big band leader, he has released "Swing! Swing! Swing!" on the Prestige label where he scats, plays bass, drums and keyboards and generally swings like crazy.

Duffy was interviewed in New York City on October 17, 1995 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and we're very happy to have with us Duffy Jackson — drummer, singer, bass player — I know it's on your resume.

DJ: I'm a jack of all trades, master of some, I don't know.

MR: And it's a great pleasure to have you here.

DJ: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Would you like to tell us about what you were doing today?

DJ: This is the most incredible day of my life it seems, and I've had a few very interesting occasions in the history of music, being the son of a bass player. You know my dad, Chubby Jackson, has permitted me to exist in some very unique musical environments and situations, but today I was very, very honored to be part of a photograph for *Life* magazine of the greatest musicians of all time in the history of jazz. There were hundreds of them actually. I mean they were only supposed to have around maybe eighty musicians originally scheduled, but then all of a sudden the word got out and everyone wanted to be part of it. It was an opportunity to meet and greet and hug and kiss a whole bunch of the great masters of our American music. And I've been big fans of every one of them and there are a bunch of the younger contingent out there too, and just to meet them in a casual way and to exchange phone numbers and hugs and stuff like that, it was a very meaningful experience. I was permitted, through my dad's association with *A Great Day In Harlem* movie, where yesterday they went back to that same spot up there, uptown, and took a picture with the remaining survivors. Two gentlemen, Ernie Wilkins and Sonny Rollins were unable to attend. But the rest of the folks were there, and what a

thrill and honor just to stand in the background and watch them standing out on the street, freezing, you know, but taking a great photograph by the legendary Gordon Parks. And it was such a thrill just to be there.

MR: I think it's fantastic that these gentlemen are getting their due. You know some of them have been household names for quite a while but most of them, you know, played a lot of years before they became — got the recognition they deserved.

DJ: Most definitely, and they're thrilled that the intellectual sophistication and understanding of the music is starting to seep into the masses a little bit more. You know education plays such a tremendous part, as you know, and that's why I'm very grateful to be associated with you in this project.

MR: Yeah, it's been really interesting meeting so many great players and hearing what they all have to offer about the music. I wanted to ask you about what you're up to these days too.

DJ: Well, almost 240, but I'm working on it here. No, but, it's an amazing thing. I've been living in South America recently — Ft. Lauderdale. It's a lovely place to be, and I've lived there off and on for years. But I'm born and raised in New York and I have to come home every once in a while and get my shot of adrenaline and get pushed around musically by the big boys a little bit. But the whole thing is just re-energizing your soul with the New York spirit, you know.

MR: I can only guess at that, because I only visit New York occasionally, and it's so overwhelming. I can imagine what you're saying.

DJ: Just driving here from the picture shoot to get here is overwhelming. I'm not the best driver in the world — I'm learning — you get in New York in that traffic jam. But everything is music though, I mean rhythms and accents. That has motivated me all my life. So even when I'm driving in traffic I'm always thinking rhythms and accents and how people might hit me, and a beeping horn somewhere sounds like the Stan Kenton brass section.

MR: Right. The rhythm of the city.

DJ: Yeah, most definitely.

MR: Oh, I have to compliment you — this is a great piece of work.

DJ: Thank you, Monk. This is my debut CD. I hope everyone enjoys it.

MR: And I'm wondering where all these young players come from — there is some hot stuff on here.

DJ: A lot of these guys are wonderful musicians, you know? I owe them a lot of money at this point, but that's—they're still friendly.

MR: Yeah. They won't forget about it.

DJ: The most important thing is they gave me an opportunity to musically expose them to the world, you know. Because Milestone Fantasy has been very kind to help promote my

career at the moment, and Mr. Bob Weinstock, who used to, who started Prestige Records, he's graciously come out of semi-retirement down in Florida to produce some records for Milestone now, and I'm very, very honored and thrilled that I could be part of his, you know, return into the industry.

MR: How was recording this big band record different from some of the other big band recordings you may have done?

DJ: Well, just to have some say-so in what's going on in the music. I mean usually the drummer can take a certain amount of rhythmic charge. But when I'm a side man I do what I'm told obviously (sometimes I've been accused of certain things). But this time I had free reign to express myself and to put together a certain order and selection of tunes that I felt the people would enjoy hopefully. And you know the main thing, being a drummer, I'm trying to aim the beat at your feet. And I'm trying to put the grin on the groove. And I try to help you to have a certain understanding of the music. Because there are many millions of people out there clapping on the first and third beats.

MR: Isn't that amazing?

DJ: And I have a lot of compassion for them, although I respect that they can latch on to the pulse of the groove in any way, shape or form that they can, you know. But just to musically give certain people that may not be the household names yet an opportunity to say hey, here I am and I'm trying to be one of the chosen few. And I think the chemistry on the album is very infectious.

MR: Yeah. It's a happy, it's in the feet. You know it's funny you mention that because I notice, even in Utica, when you do some teaching in the city, and the kids clap along with the music it's always on two and four. You move out in the suburbs, all of a sudden it's on one and three. Like where is the line that that happens? It's very interesting.

DJ: Well you know all you have to do, is if you play a swing beat like [scats] and they're clapping on one and three, then you go [scats] and then they'll turn it around. I don't know, any way that you have to get to people. You know reverse psychology for positive effect is a miraculous tool in this world you know. And if you can help people to feel a certain momentum from the groove, then all of a sudden they say well hey, we may not understand what's being played musically by the horn players, but at least we latch on to the rhythmic feeling of the music. And you know, in as much as bebop is such an intense expression of improvisation, I really enjoy being more into the swing concept of music. Because it's beneath certain musicians' dignity to play for dancing. But as a drummer and as a musician, I love to see people moving to the groove.

MR: Yeah. Didn't you learn from a tap dancer?

DJ: Most definitely. Steve Condos, who is part of the famous Condos Brothers dance team. When I was four years old, my dad taught me pulse and groove from a bass player, and

then I learned rhythms and accents from a tap dancer. So that's a unique way to approach the drums. And the gentleman that took Davy Tough's place in the Woody Herman band with my father, his name is Don Lamond, he's still with us, very healthy and happy in Orlando, Florida, and still playing great, and he definitely taught me a lot about just the technique of the drumset. I also worked out with Roy Burns for a while when I was around the ages of six and seven or so. And when I was five years old, Gene Krupa gave me a drum lesson on my dad's T.V. show. And I showed up for the T.V. show and I had my little tuxedo on, and here's this guy telling me, "Play the tom toms." I said, "Who's this guy telling me to play the tom toms?" Well anyway, I later on learned it was Gene Krupa. But you know I've been extremely blessed to have some of the jazz masters take me under their wing and just hold me on their knee and treat me with love. I mean it's given me such a dedication and desire to put this energy back into the younger people's hearts. That's why I kind of bill myself as the Johnny Appleseed of jazz. Because a lot of people need to get a shot of Duffyitis you know.

MR: Yeah, I can agree with that. And it's good because that whole tradition of the swing era, you know, eventually those fellows will all be gone. We hate to think about it. But guys like yourself can keep that thing going.

DJ: I would like to kind of keep the legacy of the swing groove alive. You know there are a lot of the younger funk, rock drummers that are coming up trying to play more of the fusion jazz. But they don't really understand the basic elements of just straight ahead swinging. You know, now you don't really need a lot of education to know how to swing, you just have to let that ultimate feeling overtake your being. And then all of a sudden you latch on to a certain groove and you know you just start learning the vocabulary. It's like people say well you can't learn jazz, you know. But it's all vocabulary you know. If you go [scats] then all of a sudden you're understanding triplets and certain rhythmic feelings that will perpetuate the swing feel.

MR: Do you have trouble teaching students to really swing? Is it a listening thing more?

DJ: Not really. I'll tell you I have a little concept of thought where if I can teach you how to scat certain rhythmic and melodic figures — for example if you can say [scats] , and then take a little rest and take a breath, if you feel the triplets with certain accents, like [scats] if you can swing the triplets like that then you can fall right into the pocket of the groove, and then you'll be able to swing at any tempo. Because you can go [scats] or [scats]. So whatever tempo, if you understand how to swing triplets, that will help you to swing.

MR: That's interesting because we'll probably talk about swinging at a slow tempo in a few minutes.

DJ: It's hard to do. It's not as easy as you would think. It's harder to play slow because you have to really give each beat its full value, which is a direct quote from Freddie Green.

You know I was playing with the Basie band in Cincinnati years ago with Count Basie, and we were playing with the Cincinnati Symphony. And we were at rehearsal and we were playing something very soft and precious. And at the end of the take, you know, Freddie Green turned around to me and said, "Give each beat its full value of time." I said, "Freddie, you never talked to me so much before." But it was a classic statement. And I've shared it with thousands of young students. You know because that's really the essence of life. Give each beat its full value of time. You know Freddie was such a master to me, he really was. I got the biggest hug from him when I left the band the last time I saw him. I don't know if he was hugging me 'cause I was leaving or, I don't know. But anyway, he didn't really talk to too many people. But I did hear through the grapevine that he had some very sweet things to say about me and I learned so much about him, that's why I dedicated a tune to him, "Blues for Freddie Green" on my CD.

MR: Now, it seems like I read you sat in with Basie when you were just a kid.

DJ: Yeah, twelve years old. You know, and it's ironic too because Don Lamond was substituting for Sonny Payne for that two week engagement at the Riverboat at the Empire State Building here years ago. That would have been almost, around 1966 or so. And it was the last set on a Thursday night and at that time they were still playing three or four sets for dancing, you know. And there weren't really a lot of people there. And so Don Lamond leaned over to Basie and said, "Hey, how about letting Duffy play one?" You know so Basie got me up there, and we're playing "Shiny Stockings," the great Frank Foster classic. And we're swinging, and Sweets was on the band and Marshall Royal was still there, all the great members were still there of that 60s era band. And so we're swinging and people are dancing and all of a sudden like everything's happening, and all of a sudden they go to play the real soft ensemble right before the end where the big ensemble comes in. And so then everybody stopped playing and so I said well if everybody stopped then I guess I should stop too. So Basie looked over and said, "Play boy!" And I went [scats], and luckily I finished the chart, but I didn't really know the arrangement and there was no written music up there on the bandstand. So consequently I got through the chart okay and you know it was a great experience, although I felt a little strange that I didn't really know the arrangement like I should have. So around seven years later, I was playing down at the Boca Raton Hotel in Florida. My father and I were appearing with Edie Adams and her husband Pete Candoli at the time, who my dad played with Pete in Woody's band. So anyway, we did our show and then the Basie band was playing a dance for the Heart Association up in the Grand Ballroom. So we packed up and we ran to see the last set, and Sonny Payne was playing drums with the band again. And for some reason I think Sonny might have had maybe a couple of extra drinks or whatever, so Basie said, "You feel like playing?" And I said, "Oh I'd love to." So I

think I fell down running to the drums or something, but I get there, and you know the first song I had to play was "Shiny Stockings." And when it came to that point where I had to play what I had to play, I looked at Basie and he looked at me and I said, "Don't worry, I think I know what I have to do this time." And I got through the song, and he kept me up there for the last ten tunes of the night. And it was such a thrill. But what's wild, I get an emergency phone call from Count Basie around four nights later. And this is a beautiful story. I lived in Miami at the time. And my car broke down and was in the shop so I rented a car. And I drove up to Palm Beach to see some of my friends and we were having a big barbecue and everything. And all of a sudden an emergency call, my dad gets on the phone and says, "Hey Basie needs you in Daytona Beach like in three hours." You know, unfortunately, Sonny Payne had a death in the family. So I drove like a maniac, I'm telling you, like one hundred miles an hour, all the way. I stopped at some little store and bought a white shirt 'cause I was in my jeans and a tee shirt or something. So I get up there around ten minutes before the job and I'm like this, you know. And Sonny Payne said, "I'll play tonight, and you play the next two nights." But I was psyched up to play that night you know. So I says phew, okay, all right. You know so I sat there eating a big steak dinner watching the band groovin'. And Sonny, with unbelievable tears running down his face all night long, played some of the greatest big band drums I had ever heard in my life. And in between tunes he was like, you know he had like a fifth of gin and he was guzzling it in between, right on the bandstand. And it was a very soulful experience. I didn't know whether to cry or be so happy or whatever. So that night, I followed the band bus back to Tampa, which is on the west coast of Florida, from Daytona Beach. Now Sonny Payne came with me, in my car, and we talked all the way back to Tampa following the band bus there. So we get to the hotel and Sonny says, "Don't worry, go to sleep in my room here," and he was leaving to go to the airport to fly to California. And so that next night we played a concert in Clearwater, and I played Sonny's drums, Sonny's cymbals, I didn't have any of my own equipment with me. And it was one of the swinginest concerts in the world, and I knew all the arrangements without the music, I just had to sit back and play. And I had chills like you would not believe playing Sonny Payne's drums and everybody was swinging and the crowd was loving everything and Basie was smiling. You know people don't get to learn on a job like that. I mean it's just impossible, I mean there are no jobs like that anymore.

MR: Yeah, that's unfortunate.

DJ: But anyway — I'm sorry I don't mean to cut you off — but the next day, we had to drive back to the east coast and we were playing at Cape Canaveral or Cocoa Beach or something, you know, a private dance. Now the first night I played was a concert, which was great. But the second night was a dance. And you know I actually almost preferred to

play dances with the Basie band because it was a different feeling entirely, you know, as far as the selections of arrangements we would play. We wouldn't really be doing the concert material. But people could dance right upside to the bandstand and be like this close to Basie, and it was just a very fun-loving, more relaxed concept of performing. And at the end of the night, Count Basie gave me a big hug and everything, and Sonny was coming back the next night, so he asked me what I wanted to be paid for the two nights. So I mean if I could have afforded to, I would have played for free, I would have paid him. So I said, "Well how about a bill a night?" And he looked at me like oh my God you want one hundred dollars a night? You know in those days I guess it was a lot of money you know. It still is today, I wouldn't mind having a job for a bill a night right now. So anyway I got paid two hundred dollars for the two nights, and I got in my rented car from Cocoa Beach, drove all the way back to Miami and I turned the rented car in, and the bill for the rented car was $197.12. So I made a couple of dollars. I went and got a hamburger and went home and I was, I couldn't believe I did it. But at least I got to see the State of Florida at a fast speed and you know.

MR: You're lucky you didn't have a speeding ticket on top of that or you would have been in the red.

DJ: Oh, boy, but you know—

MR: Well I love talking about the dancing thing too because a lot of the older musicians we've talked about have mentioned the fact that this music, much of jazz, was made for dancing.

DJ: Most definitely, yeah.

MR: And sometimes when it's moved into the concert hall, you know, jazz certainly can belong in a concert hall, but it does change it, and maybe not always for the better. I don't know. When you play for dancing, you can tell right away if you're doing it right, especially with let's say the over-50 set, I've found that they know the right tempos that they want to dance to. And they know the feel. If you're doing it right you'll see it.

DJ: You know I met a lot of fans over in Paris recently, playing for dancing. There's a couple of little dance clubs that I frequent when I'm over there. And you know you hit it right on the head. They know the tempos that they can do their steps to. So why should musicians say well hey, I want to play this song just a little bit brighter to put an edge on the groove for excitement. Why not slow the tempo down where people can really get in the groove of the music and once you flood the dance floor, you have their hearts forever. And you're always trying to go to Europe and help good will and be a good will ambassador with a groove or whatever, but a lot of the jazz people, unfortunately, their opinion is that it's beneath their dignity to play for dancing. And I've never understood that. Because for jazz to really be popular again with the masses, you have to aim the beat at their feet. You

know, and I look at it that I want to see what you're made of rhythmically. I want to see how you react to the groove a little bit. So I can play the tempo real slow and juicy and get a groove going, and I know that you will not be able to sit still. You have to get up and start moving, even if there's no dance floor. You know so that mindset is very important when you're trying to communicate what is considered contemporary music to the younger people today, because they don't know about Gene Ammons and Sonny Stitt and all these people. And you know I just recently recorded a CD on Milestone with Turk Mauro, who plays baritone saxophone and tenor sax. He was with Buddy Rich's band for years. And he's lived in Paris for years. But we just recorded a tribute to Gene Ammons. We recorded all of his old hits, you know, and we had Dr. Lonnie Smith on organ and Jeff Grubbs, a great bassist from Ft. Lauderdale played on a few tunes. And you know we just played beautiful tempos where people could get that feeling going. And that's really what's missing in today's scheme of things. I mean I would prefer that the instrumentalists that are expressing themselves melodically, just slow down the tempos and really start to play with more soul. You know, because the people need that more so than dazzling you with total technique and ability to play fast tempos. I mean I can, I pride myself on being able to play as fast and as long and as loud and hard as you want. But what about playing triple pianissimo at a slower tempo and creating the same dynamic intensity in the groove as if you were really playing hard? Now that's a mindset. I mean I always say mind control is everything. Your body does not tell your mind what to do, your mind tells your body what to do. So if you understand your objective of well hey, there's 400 people out here and I'm almost positive that at the end of the concert that they're going to be totally blown away by what I want to present to them. Because you know Woody Herman said this to my father many years ago, "Get them before they get you." If you don't get 'em, forget about it. You know you're not going to get 'em. So I mean there is a concept of thought by the musicians. I think Miles Davis started this years ago — forget that the audience is there and play for your own enjoyment. Now that's the exact opposite concept that I've been taught by my father Chubby Jackson. In other words, groove the audience's brains out. And hopefully you might have a little fun while you're doing it and if you have the mindset that you want to be utilized by the great spirit above that's making this all possible, to be utilized to help soothe people's souls in a world of ridiculousness. Because I mean we're constantly being tested to see if we have what it takes in this world. And that's why I'm here, to soothe your soul and hopefully help you to laugh a little bit, because the groove is swinging.

MR: One of my favorites of all time was Cannonball Adderley, not only because of the great way that he played but the fact that he talked to the audience—

DJ: Oh, most definitely.

MR: He included them in what he was doing.

DJ: Well he was an educator until the day he left us. And I just gave Nat Adderley a big hug before, like 25 minutes ago, saying, "Man I love you so much." You know people that know him intimately call him Naddely, but that's another story. But you know the wild part about it there is a certain feeling about making music with either your brother — like Nat and Cannonball; or your father — Chubby and Duffy; or the Wynton Marsalis family, with all those great Marsalises. You know there's something about making music with your family. You know now both my sisters sing and one of my sisters — J.J.— plays percussion, whatever. But you know I think we did one or two nights as a family. The "White Jacksons" actually. But it was a big success, that's why we broke up the group, we said we can't get any better than that so forget it.

MR: It's all downhill from here, so—

DJ: You know it's amazing, my dad and I, as far as I'm concerned, I don't know maybe you can enlighten me to this, but I consider us to be the only father and son bass and drum team in the whole history of jazz. Now there might be certain people I'm not aware of. But as far as people that have come up and tried to keep the American art form alive, you know my dad played in Woody Herman's band without a bass amp, and you heard every note. Now that means he pulled those strings. So there was the human element of emotions. And you know my father and the whole Woody Herman band at that time, they couldn't wait to hit the bandstand, just to play. Now where is that dedication today, where a lot of the people are saying, "Hey man, how much does it pay?" and all this kind of stuff. You know you have to know why you're being permitted to play this great American music. You know I mean I'm a fan of every style of music, and I'm also attempting to be an astute observer of why Garth Brooks is a multi-millionaire, and why Michael Jackson and not Duffy Jackson is successful or whatever. But I mean I need to learn from everyone's concept of performance and entertainment. That's why I'm trying to figure out what should I record on my next record, being that I've played such great swing music and tried to play with a lot of energy. Now that may not be in vogue on a recording today. Because they have a lot of music stations that kind of program their music to mellow you out from the day's activities and they don't really don't want to hear any straight ahead swinging, hard driving cooking.

MR: Yeah. Music that you could kind of half listen to.

DJ: Yeah. I call it "Quaalude Jazz."

MR: Quaalude jazz, okay.

DJ: But you know I'm here to wake you up. I'm giving you the groove wake up call of a lifetime. And I'm so thrilled to be utilized in this world right now, not only as an educator — I don't have a degree but I've backed up some of the greatest people of all time in jazz

and I feel that gives me, you know whatever I need to go to schools and just say hey, please utilize me in any way, shape or form that you can.

MR: Well, you know having a degree doesn't necessarily mean that you have what it takes to get it across to people. And I feel that the experience, the life experience is the most important thing. I mean if you're trying to tell someone how to go play a gig, well you better have played some gigs yourself.

DJ: Most definitely, yeah.

MR: You know not just in the classroom.

DJ: You know what I find is that a lot of band leaders are not drummers and they do not know how to tell their drummers what to do. So I just had the pleasure of writing an article in *DownBeat* magazine on how to lead a band from the drum chair. Now you could have the greatest band, the greatest arrangements, the greatest soloists, but if you have a mediocre drummer then you have a mediocre band. Now I'm here to tell you that drummers should unite and start to put together certain musical aggregations that they can determine who solos, how many choruses, what tempos, how to pace a set. You know I learned so much from Count Basie, I really did. You know he used to be a drummer. I think he got fired off of most of the gigs he played as a drummer so he had to switch to the piano. But years ago when he was a little kid he used to sit right at Fats Waller's feet and listen to Fats play the organ for silent movies and stuff. But I mean Count was a drummer who played piano. Now I'm a drummer that has more of piano player's mentality. I love the piano so much, but it's very difficult to really play and learn all those keys and learn how to sight read all that music so and that's why I'm a drummer. But down deep I have a piano player's mentality when I approach music. I can sit down at the piano and I don't even know the names of the chords I'm playing at times, but I just search for voicings, and I try to play pretty chords, you know or whatever. And I love to play the blues and everything. But drummers need to gain some insight on how to put musical groups together. Like Art Blakey with the Jazz Messengers. He was one of the greater leaders of all time. And he was a drummer. Now if drummers would take more control over you know just taking care of the performance and who plays what and tempos and pacing of sets, I think it would start a new era of how to present jazz with the beat. Now drummers usually are in the background accompanying the artistry of all these great horn soloists. But a lot of the horn soloists just play the melody and then they'll go on for a half hour and stretch it out and most musicians may understand and enjoy what they're doing, but how do you reach those people that love Willie Nelson so much and you're trying to influence them and enlighten them to another understanding? So that's where I'm trying to find my niche in the industry right now, being able to find out, well hey, I want to play a little bit hipper than country & western but I want to play a little bit

away from the far out bebop and just get in to the hard-driving, high energy swing that makes you laugh because it's so happy. You know people have to not take themselves so seriously sometimes on a bandstand. And I think it would be to the benefit of the audience too, overall.

MR: Well put. Let me ask you about when you were young. You must have had some tremendous opportunities because of your father.

DJ: Most definitely.

MR: Were your tastes then a little bit out of the ordinary with people your own age?

DJ: Oh, yeah, I had a few friends that were into jazz you know, but only on certain occasions would I run into a younger musician that could actually play a little bit. There was a gentleman by the name of Bob Mover, an alto saxophone player, we were in seventh and eighth grades together. And we shared a lot of great jazz experience around that time, hanging out with Ira Sullivan down in Florida, and some great players that Ira played with. Ira is one of our great educators. He goes to all the schools and plays, but he's given musical birth to hundreds of young musicians that he's permitted to get on the bandstand and he teaches you while you're playing. There was one time I sat in with him when I was like you know, twelve or thirteen years old. And he's standing next to me while the piano player is playing, and he's laughing and making jokes, making me laugh. And then when I was maybe not concentrating for a little while or whatever, he'd start yelling and screaming at me to make me play. And that's one way to learn, on the bandstand. I mean I would prefer not to be screamed at when I'm playing, but you know there's a time and place to reach you with musical concepts. I would prefer to be talked to off the bandstand if I'm not really doing something that you prefer, you know. But I've had so many great occasions. You know when I was four years old and five years old I had my first tuxedo and I was on my father's television show over three hundred times. You know my dad had the *Little Rascal* T.V. show in Chicago and New York City where he was the host of the show and it was called *Chubby's Rascals*. And he had three string basses with faces on them that he made all the faces, all the voices for, did all the dialogue. And he was on live locally in New York, it wasn't really a network show at that time. But I was on his show over three hundred times. And my father had an eighteen piece big band on the show in New York with little kids singing and dancing in front of the band.

MR: That's wild.

DJ: And you know I would love to have a show in today's scheme of things, you know this was before *Sesame Street* or any of the young kid shows. And my dad always, he was a pioneer of jazz education for the young kids in the schools you know. Stan Kenton really took it to some other more academic concepts at the collegiate level. But as far as just you know, playing jazz for children in the school, my dad did that in the late 40s. You

know "Bop Goes to School" — my dad had the first jazz band to ever go to a high school and play for the kids. Now I don't know if maybe other people did it before, but my dad actually documented that in the late 40s.

MR: What was the rock & roll kind of revolution? How did that kind of affect you as a drummer?

DJ: Well, it kind of affected my father a little bit more. Because around that time in let's say early 60s around that time, he was on television until around maybe 1967 or so. Then after that, you know, he wasn't really into it anymore. But times change and you have to go with the changes. My dad was, unfortunately, one of the guys that the rock & rollers said, "Hey old man, you know you've got to go to the Smithsonian Institute." And my father still had a lot of fire in the furnace and had to play some jazz. But we were trying to be gentlemen and trying to give everyone their opportunity to express themselves or whatever. But to sit back politely and wait your turn and then all of a sudden all these rock guys say, "Hey man we didn't know you could play like that." So all it is is it comes back to education. You can't play down to an audience at any time in my opinion. You have to enlighten them and educate them and encourage them and plant seeds of groove in their hearts and you know, just motivate them in a fun-loving way to search out the history of the music. You know I tell all my students to go to the library and check out some records of some guys that you've never even heard of before. I just did a tribute, around six months ago, that was filmed, it should come out some time soon. It was a tribute to all the jazz drummers of the 30s. And I was chosen to pay tribute to Cozy Cole, who was the great drummer who played with Louis Armstrong and Cab Calloway. And I had written a special arrangement of "Topsy" which was his famous drum number. It was the only million seller drum record that I know of or whatever, in 1958, but anyway I was privileged to pay tribute to Cozy Cole. And the people enjoyed that groove so much. And it was just a nice easy thing, you know, and you played the tom toms, and you have to relate to their animalistic instincts. And once you have their heart then you have their soul. And then all of a sudden you get to meet certain people. Like I wish I could go around to all the schools and just answer their questions. I don't know as much as I should about the music. I'm still learning every day. I will always be a student of the masters of the music. But at my age of 42, I've had 38 years of attempting to play the music of the great American swing jazz, and I try to go wherever around the world. And even though I may not be able to communicate verbally in their language, I reach them musically with the groove you know. So that's what helps me in my travels.

MR: Name some of the other — well, I could be picking up names off the floor all day with you I know – but who are some of your really favorite experiences you've had?

DJ: Well you know we could start at an early age playing with people like Charlie Shavers and Roy Eldridge and Ben Webster. I didn't even know who these people were but for some reason I just latched on to the groove and whatever my dad played I just went with him. And all of a sudden I'm backing up all these great people and I had no idea what was happening. And you know at four years old I could go [scats] and keep a beat. And you know the whole thing was just keeping a consistent momentum of the groove. Later on I started to learn the form of songs and knowing how to take little a four bar piece with horns and drums back and forth, and then all of a sudden working out a whole solo and everything. Now I don't technically work out drum solos, that's almost impossible to do. I mean every solo I do is spontaneously created. I might have a little bit of a rhythmic bag of tricks that I rely on if I need to or whatever, everybody does that. But in every way, when you get behind the drumset, it's almost like that's your place of meditation. And that's where you can just you know plug into that ultimately gorgeous, joyful groove of playing, and then fasten your seat belt and hang on for dear life you know. But I'll tell you something that's wild. When I graduated high school in Miami Beach, I was summoned to the principal's office one day and I said oh, no, what did I do now? I had no idea what was happening. So I walk into the principal's office, and there is my father and there is the principal of the school. And the principal comes over and kisses me on the cheek and gives me a big hug and says, "You graduated. Ray Brown and Milt Jackson need you in California tomorrow for a gig at Shelly's Manhole." Now I'd been playing with Monty Alexander's trio and Monty recommended me to Ray Brown.

MR: That's wild.

DJ: And within five hours after that I was on a flight to California. I packed my bags and dad put me on the plane and Ray Brown met me at the airport and drove me to the hotel and left me there, and like the next day I opened up with Teddy Edwards on sax, Milt Jackson, Ray Brown, Monty Alexander and myself. And for three weeks I was in a dream world like you would not believe, to play with these people. And right after that I got a phone call, now let me preface it, Louie Bellson has been a saint in my life. He helped me at the age of eighteen to become Lena Horne's drummer. And this is after her husband had passed away, who was her conductor and husband for 45 years or so. And I played the first engagement with her that she came back, and we went on a year tour with Alan King all across the country. But the miraculous part is that around I'd say around eight weeks after I had graduated high school, I was back in Miami Beach playing as Lena Horne's drummer with Alan King. And I got front row passes for all my teachers to come sit there and watch me play. I could barely read the music, I was making faces at all my teachers. But I had a ball, it was great. And you know it was wild because my father and

Lena were associated together in Charlie Barnet's big band in the early 40s before my dad joined Woody Herman's band. So Lena took extra special care of her little Chubby.

MR: How about some of the other great vocalists?

DJ: Well, after that when I was twenty years old Louie Bellson had a lot to do with getting me to be Sammy Davis Jr.'s drummer, and I was with Sammy for three years off and on at that point. And to back up one of the greatest showmen of all-time, and what was great is that all his arrangements sounded like the Count Basie band and we just had like forty strings included, and as I said before, that too was one of the great jobs to be paid to learn. You know because when you have to back up the great Sammy Davis, but also hold like a sixty piece orchestra together, you better know what you're doing. And I don't actually say that I knew what I was doing at all times, but I kept my heart wide open to any positive critique. And everyone had their own opinion of what I was doing, correctly, but Sammy was very gracious to me and I learned a lot from him. And it's not that we were too close off the stage, because he enjoyed his privacy, and I was told to stay away at certain times, whatever. But the main thing is when we were on the bandstand, he was mine, and I kicked him as hard as I could and he turned around and smiled at me on numerous occasions, you know. But then after that I said well now I'm going to make it in show business, 'cause I'm with Sammy you know. But then I said hey, I really want to play jazz. I want to get more into being able to express myself away from being an accompanist and more of a show business jazz act, and get into playing with some more straight ahead musicians. And so I started traveling again with Monty Alexander, the great Jamaican pianist. And I played with Monty off and on for over twenty-two years and then all of a sudden I get the call from Count Basie. You know I'd played with Lionel Hampton before that, whatever. And Count was starting to get a little older and Butch Miles, bless his heart, I thought he was never going to leave the band because he was there almost five years. And I said well you know, I hope I get my shot to play. And Butch wanted to give a whole bunch of different drummers an opportunity to play with the band, and plus he wanted to get out on his own and do his own thing too. So the phone rang one night and it was Count himself. And he said, "What are you doing, Duffy?" And I said, "I'm waiting for Butch to get off that band, you know, so I can get there." But the wild part about it, and this does not happen in any situation that I know of. Count Basie and Butch Miles gave me seven months to prepare. I had seven months knowing that I was going to join the band. So what I did I made around fifty cassette tapes filled with the Count Basie groove from the 30s to the present band. And I studied those tapes every day, every night I fell asleep with the headphones on, you know and woke up playing Basie. And when I joined the band, I did not have to read a note of music. Now maybe certain musicians would have preferred I read the music, but that's

only to their opinion. But the main thing is that I kept my eyes on the Count at all times and he gave me all the cues, you know, whether it was a wink of the eye or a little pinky here, or just a shrug of the shoulder, or anything, I knew what he wanted. And he taught me so much. He didn't even have to say anything, he just had to look at me you know. And I feel in my own heart that the dear Lord above put me on this earth to be the Count Basie drummer. And I was so blessed to have that opportunity to play with the Count.

MR: Yeah. It's an awesome responsibility to be in that rhythm section. Who was playing bass at that time?

DJ: Well at that particular time the first three months, I joined August 12 of 1979. And I stayed at that point a full year. And the bassist for the first three months I was there was John Clayton, who is an extraordinary player, he really is, he's great, whether in symphonic work or straight ahead jazz. And he's become one of the most prolific arrangers and composers and I love his writing. And he stayed for three months, but he had been on the band a few years and he wanted to settle down with his family in Los Angeles and start to work in the studios. You know he's been extremely successful with that. And then a gentleman came on the band, Cleveland Eaton. He had played with Ramsey Lewis and a few people.

MR: I think he was with the group that — we saw them not that long ago.

DJ: Yes. He's been with the band off and on all these years. Yeah. He has great stamina to play and travel like that. I really commend his endurance. But we had a wonderful time. What I can say, John Clayton was very elegant with his approach you know, to playing in the rhythm section. And when Cleveland Eaton came, he put a real greasy groove which was necessary to the Basie sound, and that gave us a certain spark and a certain element of the groove that Basie loved so much. And it became a new era in the band. And we had a very, very great time playing together, Cleve and I and the band, with Freddie Green and you know, just to be part of that all-American rhythm section. Unfortunately staying a full year in the band and packing up and setting up the drums every night and traveling on the bus and lifting your luggage and you know, physically, it was very demanding on me. And unfortunately I've had to have a few surgeries in my lifetime. I was spiked playing Little League baseball when I was eight years old, and it developed into osteomyelitis, which is what Mickey Mantle had. So I needed to have a few hip operations through the years, but I would always come back to swing the Basie band or whoever would give me an opportunity to play. Physically it's a little hard in the cold weather at times to pack up and set up drums and move around, but right now being in Florida the last few, year and a half or so, I've regained my health to the point where I'm back in New York ready to wail as hard as I can. You know this is the best therapy in the world just to swing.

MR: Sometimes the younger musicians that, well like myself, I always wanted to do a big band, but I never saw the downside of it perhaps — that night after night.

DJ: It's unfortunate that it's so difficult as far as the demands on your physical well being, to get out there. But you're so pumped up there from the adrenaline of meeting people and going to different places and enjoying the atmosphere of different places every night of your life, and just the admiration that you're receiving from the audiences and everything. So it keeps you pumped up with the adrenaline but if you take more than two or three days off, if you get a week off or something, you totally collapse. So Basie, at one point, we were about ready to take a ten day break coming back from the Japan tour of 1980. And Basie was feeling so good at that time, that he was afraid. He didn't want to take a ten day break because he would have totally collapsed. So we went into six to eight weeks of one nighters. And that's what started to break him down physically. He really should have taken that time off to heal himself. But the band was swinging so hard, he wanted to keep that momentum happening, and that was one of the great bands. If you dig right around 1979, 80, during that period, one of the reasons we were so thrilled is that I had just joined the band like around a week before his birthday which was the 21st of August. And for the next six weeks after that, we were given unbelievable parties for his 75th anniversary. And it was very difficult to actually play the music. We were partying a little bit too much actually. But we had such a ball, and Basie was so gracious to me. When we played the Kennedy Center Honors in 1979, we surprised Ella on that particular show. She had no idea we were going to be there. And when we set up and everything at rehearsal, and we were ready to go, we had no idea what we were going to play. Count Basie pulled out my drum solo number. And I had chills, I almost fell off the drum stool actually. But I was permitted to play "Whirly Bird" — the great Neal Hefti composition — and all the great drummers that have played in the Basie band at one time or another have been permitted to play that number as their drum solo. And I did the best I could to not embarrass myself too much on that situation, and there was just so much love, and all the people in the audience, and Ella was crying, and Jon Hendricks and Joe Williams and Peggy Lee were singing with the Basie band for Ella. And it was definitely one of the highlights of my career. And I've been so blessed to back up Joe Williams on numerous occasions with the Basie band. You know there was one night at the Waldorf here in New York. We were playing a private party and it was kind of a dance, not really a concert. And the band was swinging and Joe Williams was singing. And Joe Williams came up to me after the job and kissed me right on the lips. I almost blacked out for a minute I couldn't see and I said oh, Joe Williams. But it felt good too actually, but I don't want to admit that to too many people. There are only three men that have actually kissed me on the lips, was my father, and Dizzy and Joe Williams.

MR: Well that's a pretty good trio, actually.

DJ: But Joe Williams was trying to tell me in that way, relax, you have the job. Because I was trying to kick the band and we were in New York and it was swinging and exciting, and you know, there is certain subtleties and nuances to the Basie music, that if you really don't study the band from the 40s and the 50s, you would really just play right through them and want to swing hard through sections that you should really play a little softly and with more intensity but at a softer volume. The subtle nuances is what makes jazz so personable and gives it that personality. So Joe Williams kissed me on the lips. That was his way of telling me to relax, that I had the job you know.

MR: That's interesting because a lot of the stories I've read about some of the band leaders and especially Basie is that they didn't always tell you exactly what they wanted in words. It was more with gestures.

DJ: Oh yes.

MR: And if they didn't tell you, you were doing okay. And he had a hard time firing people is that right?

DJ: Yes, most definitely. It's very rare that you would be able to upset the Count. He was a very beautiful human being that had a lot of compassion and sensitivity for people. When he had to be total business he knew what to do. Unfortunately when he would receive information that one of the former members had maybe passed away or something like that, and we were in a rehearsal or just getting ready to go on stage or something, he would only give it two seconds thought, "Okay, straight ahead we have to go." But maybe later on he would have his moment of silence for them. But I learned a lot about the show must go on concept. We were in, let's see, somewhere in Omaha or something. And we played an engagement there. And we were going to Dallas the next day to play a dance. And one of the gentlemen, Charlie Fowlkes, who played baritone saxophone in the band, he was always dressed to travel every day in a shirt and tie, because of the respect of being seen, you know, he wanted to carry on that tradition of just being classy and being dressed all the time when he was in public. But he was always the first one down in the lobby every day with his luggage, ready to go, you never had to — you might have had to call my room saying, "Duffy, are you ready, the bus is—" you know. I have a very interesting story before I relate that story about Charlie. My first night on the band, we had rehearsed in New York City and I had a brand new set of drums, brand new cymbals, everything. I was ready to go. And so we packed up and we went up to Cohasset, Massachusetts to play at the South Shore Music Circus up there. And we were running a little late in traffic, and we get there with only maybe less than a half hour to set up before we had to play. And the place was packed, ready to go, and there was a theater in the round you know? So I set up my drums, and I said, "Where's my cymbals?"

Unfortunately my cymbals and my stick bag were left in New York City by accident. And fortunately enough, Vic Damone and a big orchestra, they were rehearsing to open up there the next day, in the little rehearsal room off to the side there. So I ran in and cut off the rehearsal and said, "Excuse me Bas' I'll be right with you," and I went over the Vic's drummer and I said, you may not know who I am but in around ten minutes I'm going to make my debut with the Count Basie orchestra, and I'm taking your cymbals and your sticks and your brushes, and incidentally what is your name please? I don't even remember his name.

MR: Were you bigger than him?

DJ: No, no, but, and I should have had a twenty in my back pocket.

MR: But you had a reason.

DJ: I stopped Vic Damone's rehearsal, and took his drummer's sticks and brushes and cymbals and ten minutes later I was swinging the Basie band. I will never forget that. And the next night we were playing in a place called the Robin Hood Dell, it's a big amphitheater in Philadelphia. And we bussed it from New York and went to Philly and everything. Now I unfortunately had to wait, they couldn't stop in New York to get my cymbals, but they put my cymbals on a bus, on a Greyhound, to Philadelphia, and Count Basie himself and the whole band waited on the bus for close to 45 minutes while I went downtown to the bus station, got caught in a big traffic jam in a cab, it cost like $50 in a cab, to get my cymbals. And when I got on the bus, I looked at Basie and I said, "Sorry, Count," you know I called him "The Chief" you know everybody called him "The Chief." I said, "Sorry, Chief, you know I'll try not to make this a habit." So we go and we play the gig and it was with Arthur Prysock and everything, I mean 25,000 people and they were swinging, you know, groovin'. The next day we played a little country club gig, and by that time I was so exhausted, I didn't even know what day it was. And all of a sudden the phone rings, and I was like twenty minutes late getting on the bus. And you know I said, "Oh I'll be down in a minute." And all my stuff was all unpacked, all over the room. I packed in less than three minutes, was on the bus, and I looked at the Chief and I said, "I don't know what to tell you." But then I went out and I bought a clock and a watch and everything, you know. But my first 72 hours on the band were a little strange there. But Chief really had a lot of compassion and he permitted me to just get in sync with the rest of the band, and it took a few days but I was just really loving his spirit so much every night. And just looking at him and traveling with him every day and everything, and you know I tried not to bother him too much you know, but every once in a while he'd say, "Hey Duffy come on over here," and I'd sit and he'd tell me some stories and stuff. But to have the, pardon the pun, "duffstinction" of playing on three different Basie bands, you know, playing with the Count in 1979 and 80. And then I

came back in January of 1985. Count had passed on and Thad Jones took over the band. And that was a very unique experience because the Count Basie Orchestra had never had another leader before. And there was a certain contingent in the orchestra that felt that they didn't really need a leader. But in one way, to salvage all the work that was being canceled in many ways, the people didn't want the Count Basie band without the Count. Although we still played the great music and unfortunately the band had to play for a lot less money, being that Count wasn't there, and it was very difficult financially to keep the band out of bankruptcy. So they needed a great name like Thad Jones to come in and help the band and Thad was very interesting in the band in the first couple of months, because we didn't really get together and rehearse right away. Thad just stood in front of the band and made announcements and counted off some tempos. Then all of a sudden he started to write some great arrangements, in my opinion not really in the style of the Basie band. But he was permitted to experiment and after a while it started to sound closer to what he was trying to do with Thad and Mel's concept. And certain audiences said hey wait a minute, we want to hear the older Basie sound. But they were intrigued and you know, it was a very interesting time to be on the band. Now unfortunately I'd just had my surgery around eight or nine months before that or whatever — actually, I'm sorry, three months before I rejoined the Basie band — I got an emergency call that they needed me. And I was on crutches still, but you know what? If I was on my death bed I'd get up and play with the Basie band. I mean you know that was my dedication you know? So on crutches, I joined the band at the Blue Note in New York City, not knowing whether I'd get through the first number, the first set, the first night. And through the grace of God I built up my endurance and stamina to be able to play, and I lasted almost around I'd say around eight months before I needed to almost have my surgery re-done again. So I knew that physically it was not the time for me to try to make a comeback with the band. So I went down to Florida and played with my father. He was living in Vero Beach of all places. And for the next five months I played two nights a week with my dad, you know, three sets a day, you know, and then the other five nights I was bedridden, you know, just taking physical therapy to build myself back up. And then when it was time I went down to Miami and got into some gigs. And then when I really felt good enough, I went back to New York and said, "Hey, anybody remember me?" So I've had to come back from surgeries on a few occasions, but that's what keeps me totally dedicated. Then coming back to the Basie band in 1989, with Frank Foster, I rejoined the band three days before we recorded the album "The Legend and Legacy of the Count Basie Orchestra," which was nominated for a Grammy on Denon, a Japanese label. And it was a very big thrill to record an album with the Basie band with George Benson, "Big Boss Man" on Warner Brothers. And I played with the band for around

eighteen months at that time, and then physically it started to break me down again, whatever, and I said well I think the time has come to let some younger drummers have an opportunity, you know. And I feel that if I can get in front of a group of musicians and not have to play the drums on every number, and play a little piano, a little bass, scat, work the crowd a little bit, like Dizzy used to do, you know, that's sorely needed I feel in the industry. You know my father and I have been called the "jazz vaudevillians" in certain ways. Now in many ways, with the jazz purists, they felt that it was a little strange to be extroverted performers. But now you see all the great jazz players attempting to do a little shtick and get on the mic and talk a little bit to the folks. It's sorely needed I feel, to bridge the gap right now.

MR: Yeah. And I think if you're familiar with the history of jazz that that's where the music came from. It was music, but it was entertainment too.

DJ: Yeah, most definitely.

MR: You know, so I don't think you have to apologize for putting some life into the music like that.

DJ: You know getting back to that story about Charlie Fowlkes, it's not a pleasant one unfortunately, but about the show must go on concept that Basie had. Charlie Fowlkes went to sleep on the band bus just like this, and had a massive heart attack. And he was a big man, he was over 320 pounds. And he bet me one hundred dollars that he could lose 30 pounds before I did. And it was just like a week ago before that that we made that bet. And it took almost ten people to lift him off the bus. And it was very strange. But you know what? Three hours later, we were on stage playing, and people were dancing right up to Basie and Basie is smiling and joking with the crowd. I was totally stunned, but I couldn't believe I was playing the drums. But you know what? Out of respect to Charlie Fowlkes' memory and to the respect and dignity of Count Basie's memory and everything, we got on the bandstand and we played. And Count was an amazing man. He got me through that night you know. And I learned so much about the show must go on. Because in many ways you may not feel like getting up there on a few occasions. You might be depressed emotionally or feeling a little under the weather physically or something. But there's something about getting on that stage and when the curtain opens, that's what heals your soul and that's what makes you who you are and separates the men from the boys or the ladies from the girls or whatever. But the main thing is play, and dedicate your life to the love of the groove, and help people to feel that joyous feeling. And that's what I think my whole dedication is all about.

MR: That's marvelous. And you know I was going to say as we wrap up here, if you have some words for our students — I think you just said them.

DJ: Well in many ways, be kind and have compassion to the other players on the bandstand playing other instruments, especially if you're a drummer. Because a lot of trumpet players might blow their chops or if you're playing too loudly behind a singer or something like that. Learn to play and generate dynamic intensity at a soft volume. And that will dedicate you to developing control and that will determine your personality behind your instrument. And I really feel that if people will permit the groove to breathe — one thing that Basie said to me, that I quoted him in my *Down Beat* article, that he came up to me one night and he said, "Please do me a favor." And I said, "Anything you want, Chief." And he says, "Please don't play bebop drums in my swing band." In other words, make all your fills self-explanatory. Don't make — you have to gain the trust of the other musicians you're attempting to create music and accompany. And if you can gain the respect of the other instrumentalists — you know they usually say, "Oh yeah, it's fourteen guys and a drummer." So drummers have to really earn the respect of the other instrumentalists. And I think by drummers just gaining more understanding of the form of the music and learning to help the soloists be inspired to create — you know the utmost compliment that I can be bestowed, is when a soloist will come up to me and say, "Man, thanks for laying down the groove, I needed to tell my story." I'm not here to play duets with horn players, I'm here to lift them up and give them such a wonderful joyous feeling to play. And if they can relate their story to the people, and then they come up to you and say, "Hey man thanks for laying down the groove," that's the greatest compliment in the world to me. So just love the groove, and keep the grin on the groove as much as you can, and aim the beat at their feet, and just hope for the best.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton College, it's been a great pleasure speaking with Duffy Jackson, who speaks as eloquently as he plays I would like to say.

DJ: Thank you.

MR: And thank you so much.

DJ: Bless you.

MR: He's had quite a day with the photo shoot.

DJ: I'm never going to forget this day, and you are a very integral part of the success and the happiness that I'm feeling right now, and all these jazz greats, phew.

MR: Okay.

DJ: I hope to come to your school sometime, and maybe jam with the students, I'd love to do that.

MR: All right.

DJ: Thank you, Monk.